

girl

i say the word

girl

and it feels wrong as it passes through my lips.

it feels forced, like it's been stuck somewhere in my throat and i'm having to, to
gargle it
up.

the 'L' stumbles off my tongue into the air where it awkwardly hangs and i
don't know how to explain that

girl

to me is something sacred i am not welcome to; a party where i am

stuck in the corner

of the kitchen with a cider sweating in my hand and makeup sweat-
ing off my face, a secret society i'll never get
in, their hooded robes a color that doesn't
suit my complexion, a point of higher
achievement i should never hope to reach
with my arms that are rounder than most.
i approach it like it's holy,

girl.

i handle it with care in

between

my dry palms, the back of my hands unlotioned and
cracking; the dark teal i painted
my nails in streaks from where i ripped it off–
it only lasted for a day.

my grip is too strong and steadfast for a woman's,
too weak and not calloused enough for a man's,
and what little i have known of

girl

starts to crumble in my grasp. i struggle to
collect the pieces of it that scatter around my scuffed and muddied shoes and withering pant legs
that pool around my feet, my frame too imposing and angular for a woman's,
too curved and smooth for a man's.

i say the word

girl

and it is just another part of me that i put on for show.

but when a man sees me and says the word

girl,

it feels like maybe i am finally fit to the mold.

his appraisal of my body that i have struggled to
embrace as it is too pillowy and lumpy for a man's,
too imposing and muscled for a woman's, warms my skin.

i drink it up, his praise, and ask him for more, and he gives it to me without batting an eye
because he is wired for it. he tells me that he likes the way my small hands wrap around his arms
and i bask in it, this dominance, because i am wired for it—until i notice how my knuckles have
turned white, my grip that is too weak and not calloused enough for a man's
and too strong and steadfast for a woman's shows me how
desperate i am
to hold onto him.

he sees me and says

girl...

and it is all i have ever wanted. someone, some man to see me as
that, as such a thing so delicate as to require a word of its own.

i want to be
to him.

girl

i want to be
finally, i want to be let into the club and invited upstairs—

girl,

but how he sees
is: something to
break.

girl

is: something he can dig his hands into and come back with a prize

girl

is: my submission.

i am not
how he sees it. i am not
to other
and that may encapsulate my identity crisis for
the rest of my existence, but i will not be

girl

girl

girl

girl

to a boy.